

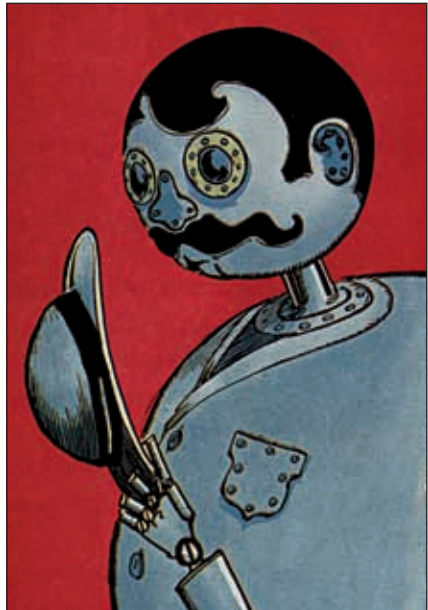
that quest, which is a common theme in sci-fi, as you'll find when you get to some of the later chapters.

The earliest reference to a mechanical intelligence, which is what all of us imagine when we think "AI" today, has to be Tik-Tok, the wind-up mechanical intelligence that L Frank Baum thought up for his Land of Oz series of books. Tik-Tok was a round copper being that had to be wound up like a watch or a clock, and had different keys that needed to be wound for thought, speech and movement. Tik-Tok is considered by most people to be the first "robot" even though that word didn't exist for a decade after his books were first published. In fact, the first known use of the word was in 1920, in a play titled Rossum's Universal Robots by Karel Čapek, a Czechoslovakian playwright, and this was a year after L Frank Baum died!

For those of you who want to point out that the Tin Man from Baum's Land of Oz series was perhaps a better fit for our imagination of AI than Tik-Tok, you should know that Baum himself said that the Tin Man was not artificially created, but in fact was a human who turned more artificial by the year as he had to have parts and organs replaced by those made of tin in order to survive.

Of course, characters from books by the likes of Asimov, Clarke, and movies such as *The Terminator* and *Matrix* have fuelled the more recent perception of AI, but those can hardly be called "Ancient", and are dealt with in a different chapter – Chapter 5, to be precise.

Going back to ancient times, we really see the initiation of AI in the process of mechanising human characteristics, or functions. One of the earliest such accounts is perhaps from Lie Yokou, a Chinese philosopher who lived around 400 BC. In a text called *Liezi* (meaning,



Tik Tok, from Baum's classic Oz series